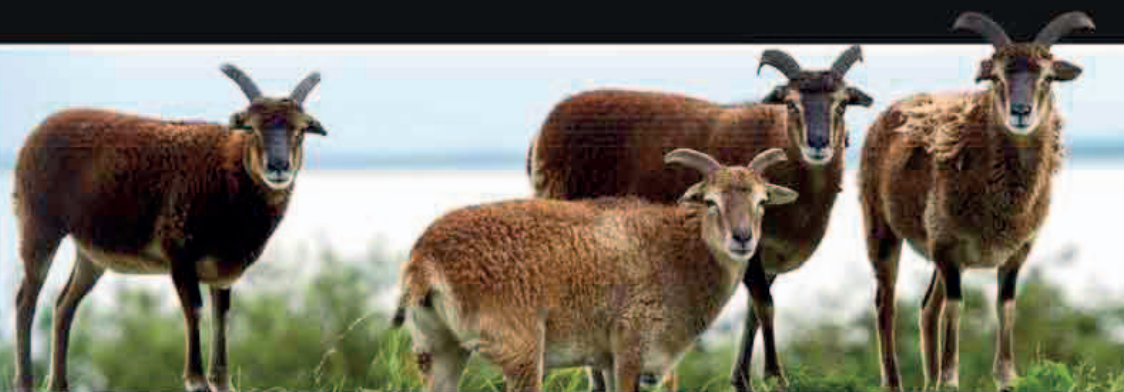


15 THOUSAND

THE MAXIMUM
NUMBER OF **SOAY**
SHEEP ALIVE TODAY



The Soay sheep is native to a small island off the west coast of Scotland. It is a primitive breed, very similar to the first domesticated sheep in Europe.



ONE OF THE FIRST ANIMALS

to be domesticated by humans, around 30,000 BCE, was the dog, which was selectively bred from domesticated wolves and was used for hunting. Around 8500 BCE, people in southwest Asia began to domesticate other animals, beginning with sheep and goats. **Cattle and pigs were domesticated** around 7000 BCE in many places across the world, and by 3000 BCE a number of other animals had been domesticated including, in the Americas, the guinea pig (around 5000 BCE) and the llama (about 4500 BCE).

The first large-scale construction of **stone buildings** began around 9000 BCE, with the building of a ritual structure

at Göbekli Tepe in southeast Anatolia (in modern Turkey). It consisted of a number of free-standing T-shaped pillars within a low circular enclosure wall. In around 8000 BCE the **first settlement wall was built** at Jericho in Palestine. Made of stone, the wall was about 16 ft (5 m) high with a circumference of 1,970 ft (600 m). **Architectural techniques became more sophisticated**, with the use of corbelling (overlapping stone to create a type of vaulted roof) in northwest Europe by 4000 BCE, and buttresses to strengthen walls in Mesopotamia by around 3400 BCE. From about 5000 BCE, the practice of building large structures using massive stones—**megaliths**—spread

throughout western Europe, resulting in structures such as the Carnac stones in Brittany, France (dating from around 4500 BCE), Newgrange Passage tomb in Ireland (around 3400 BCE), and Stonehenge in England (from 2500 BCE).

By around 6500 BCE the people of Mehrgarh (in modern Pakistan) were making bitumen, a sticky liquid that seeps from crude oil deposits, to **make reed baskets waterproof**, and around 2600 BCE the people of the Indus Civilization were using it to create a watertight coating for brick-built basins. In Mesopotamia from the 4th millennium BCE, bitumen was mixed with sand to create a mortar for building and as a **tar for caulking ships**.

Farming hillsides

The use of terraces to allow hilly areas to be farmed began in Yemen in about 4000 BCE but was also widely practiced in China and in mountainous areas of Peru.

Where there was insufficient rainfall for agriculture, farmers developed irrigation to transport water to their fields. At Choga Mami, in eastern Iraq, water channels from the Tigris River were constructed from around 6000 BCE, and by the 4th millennium BCE, **dams and dikes** were used to store water in reservoirs in parts of western Asia. In Egypt, the annual flooding of the Nile River inundated fields naturally, but from at least as early as 3000 BCE, excess water was diverted for

storage. **Terrace agriculture**, in which flat, cultivable areas are cut into a hillside and irrigated by water channels, was developed in Yemen in around 4000 BCE. In China, **networks of banks and ditches** were built to flood and drain wet-rice cultivation fields (paddies).

Cold-working (beating or hammering) of naturally occurring metals, such as gold and copper, was practiced as early as 8000 BCE. **Smelting**—heating metallic ores with a reducing agent to extract the pure metal (see 1800–700 BCE)—appeared as early as 6500 BCE in Çatal Höyük in Turkey. The technique spread widely: it was being used from southeast Europe to

ALLOYS

The combination of two or more metals produces an alloy, which may have different characteristics from the original metals. In the mid to late 5th millennium BCE, it was discovered that smelting a small amount of arsenic with copper produced arsenical bronze, which is harder and stronger than copper alone. By around 3200 BCE, true bronze was being produced in southwest Asia by using tin instead of arsenic in the smelting process, and objects such as this early 2nd century bronze figurine were being made. By the late 3rd millennium BCE, it had also been discovered that copper could be alloyed with zinc, forming brass.



c.8000 BCE First stone town wall is built, at Jericho, Palestine

c.7000 BCE Cattle and pigs are domesticated in the Near East and elsewhere

c.7000 BCE First evidence of basketry, found at Jarmo in Iraq

c.6500 BCE Bitumen is first used for waterproofing, in Mehrgarh, Pakistan

c.6500 BCE Evidence of copper smelting found at Çatal Höyük, Turkey

c.6000 BCE Earliest spindle whorls, found at Çatal Höyük, Turkey

c.6000 BCE Pottery kilns first appear, in the Hassuna culture of Mesopotamia

c.5500 BCE Copper smelting begins in southeastern Europe and the Near East

c.5500 BCE Irrigation canals are built at Choga Mami, Iraq